

MONASH University

Optimal Sortition: A Framework Analysis

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A thesis submitted for the degree of
Bachelor of Commerce (Honours)
at Monash University in 2026
Department of Econometrics & Business Statistics

Table of contents

Copyright notice iv

Abstract v

Declaration vi

Acknowledgements viii

1 Introduction 1

2 Background 2

3 Literature Review 4

4 Research Question 6

5 Research Plan 7

6 Preliminary Results 8

Bibliography 9

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The contribution in Chapter 3 of this thesis was presented in the International Symposium on Nonsense held in Dublin, Ireland, in July 2022.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

Aim:

This study aims to evaluate current sortition methods and community representation processes, as well as to investigate how unobserved traits and survey non-response may affect panel representativeness. By investigating these factors, we can develop a greater understanding of existing tools and procedures, how they work, how they fall short, what it would mean for them to be more representative, which will then enable the creation of a diagnostic tool to gauge effectiveness.

Chapter 2

Background

We live in an age where decision-making and its impacts feel like they are only growing in importance and scale, yet our ability to impart influence seems to only be diminishing. Many feel disenfranchised and like power is being taken away from them, and that their voices are not being heard. This is a problem. Not only because it can lead to disengagement, apathy, and a lack of trust in institutions, but also because *not* listening directly to lived experiences and perspectives limits the effectiveness of the very decisions we do make.

According to Flanigan et al. (2021), sortition creates groups that are statistical "mini-publics" of society, reflecting demographics and perspectives more accurately than elected bodies. Which, given the polarised and over-dramatised nature of policy today, is a much-needed breath of fresh air.

Sortition is a method of selection that uses random sampling to create panels that are representative of the population. It has been used in various contexts, reaching as far back as ancient Athens, where it was how jurors were selected, and into modern times for citizens' assemblies. The idea is that by randomly selecting individuals from the population, we can create panels that are more representative and inclusive than those selected through traditional methods. Sortition also reduces dominance by elites or highly engaged groups, enabling broader participation across social classes (Giuliani 2025), ensuring decisions actually serve the people they are meant to.

An increasing number of institutions (including the Parisian Citizens' Assembly, the Irish Citizens' Assembly, and the British Columbia Citizens' Assembly) are using sortition to create panels that are more representative of the population. However, there are still many challenges to overcome in order to ensure that these panels are truly representative and effective.

One of the main challenges is ensuring that the selection process is transparent and fair, and that the panels are truly representative of the population in terms of demographics and perspectives. But

this raises the questions of both a) what does it mean to be fair? and b) what does it mean to be representative?

Additionally, though some have already been developed, there is a need for better tools, methods and frameworks to evaluate the representativeness of these panels and to ensure that they are robust in achieving their goals.

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Chapter 3

Literature Review

LexiMin (Flanigan et al. 2021)

P_init:

- Non-empty portfolio of panels that initiates the optimisation process. As there could be exponentially many panels, it just starts with a single arbitrary panel, then iteratively produces more through column generation.

C_aux:

- Property 1: The total probability assigned to all possible panels must sum to 1 (100%).
- Property 2: The selection probability of a person is the sum of all valid panels that include them.
- Property 3: For all unfixed (unselected) people, the selection probability must be at least a defined floor (minimum selection probability).
- Property 4: For all fixed (previously selected) people, the probability will be held constant.

Overall function:

- LexiMin aims to maximise the minimum selection probability (floor) across all participants, which represents the minimum selection probability for the currently least-likely-to-be-chosen individuals.
- It uses Lambda panel-weighting to list likelihood of every given panel iteration.
- It creates a “fixed set” of participants whose probabilities were already locked in during previous iterative rounds.

- It uses rho to maintain “fixed values” for selection likelihoods of members of the “fixed set”.
- And then lumps all feasible panel sets back into the Portfolio.

Chapter 4

Research Question

What does it mean for a panel to be “good” at being representative and are we achieving this? - Are current methods and algorithms, like LexiMin, performing the best they could be? - How do unobserved/unfiltered traits affect response rates, and therefore panel composition and representativeness? - How can survey non-response and other sampling-level issues bias representativeness?

nDF suggests 10x response to panel count; not generally feasibly, more often get 3x. How much of a difference does this make to burden and selection likelihood?

Chapter 5

Research Plan

Plan

Chapter 6

Preliminary Results

This chapter contains a summary of the context in which your research is set.

Bibliography

Flanigan, B, P Gölz, A Gupta, B Hennig & AD Procaccia (2021). Fair algorithms for selecting citizens' assemblies. *Nature* **596**, 548–552.

Giuliani, A (2025). Sortition in Politics: From History to Contemporary Democracy. *Parliaments, Estates and Representation* **45**(3), 317–335.